



FASHION / CONSUMER PSYCHOLOGY / BRAND STRATEGY

## From product to symbol

WHY SOME FASHION BRANDS BECOME CULTURAL ICONS

Three distinct brand worlds. One underlying business advantage: people do not simply recognize the product they recognize what it means.

## 01 / THE CULTURAL-VALUE SHIFT

# Attention can be bought. Meaning has to be built.

The brands that remain memorable are not necessarily the loudest. They create a recognizable relationship between an object, a worldview and the people who choose to carry that meaning into everyday life.

> 1 in 2

fashion executives identify customer retention as an important industry theme in 2026. The strategic question is no longer only how to attract attention, but what makes someone stay. [01]

## AN ORIGINAL LENS: THE 4C CULTURAL-EQUITY MODEL

## 01 CODE

A visual cue, product silhouette or atmosphere that people can recognize.

## 02 COMMUNITY

A specific group that feels seen - and wants to pass the meaning on.

## 03 CONTEXT

A genuine point of view grounded in place, culture, memory or experience.

## 04 CONTINUITY

Consistent expression across products, campaigns, collaborations and time.

My analysis: Cultural relevance is not a separate marketing layer. It is the accumulated result of a product, a point of view and a community reinforcing one another over time.



Photograph: June Canedo / Courtesy of Telfar; published by Vogue.

## CULTURAL ROUTE / BELONGING

# Telfar: the status of being included

"It's not for you - it's for everyone."

## THE INDUSTRY OBSERVATION

Traditional luxury often uses restricted access to signal status. Telfar positions its unisex Shopping Bag around broad cultural participation instead. [02]

## THE CONSUMER BEHAVIOR

The customer is not only buying a useful bag. They are signaling belonging, shared values and recognition within a visible community.

## THE STRATEGIC MECHANISM

A consistent silhouette and embossed emblem make the product legible; friends-and-family casting makes the community credible. The Bag Security Program has offered timed pre-orders. [03][04]

## THE COMMERCIAL TENSION

Demand can create excitement, but persistent inaccessibility can contradict an inclusive promise. The business challenge is to protect desirability without weakening trust.

## WHAT AN EMERGING BRAND CAN BORROW

Build one recognizable hero product, feature actual community members and offer a transparent 48-hour pre-order window. Track repeat purchases, customer-created content and pre-order conversion rather than treating sell-outs alone as proof of loyalty.



**CULTURAL ROUTE / RECOGNITION**

# Jacquemus: a world before a logo

A lavender-field runway is not merely an attractive location. It is a shorthand for an entire emotional universe.

**THE RECOGNIZABLE CODE**

The brand's SS20 presentation in Valensole turned landscape, color and a distinctive runway into an instantly repeatable visual memory. [05]

**THE CONSUMER BEHAVIOR**

People share images that help express an aspirational identity. The desire is not only for a handbag or outfit; it is for access to a recognizable lifestyle and mood.

**WHY THE STORY STAYS CREDIBLE**

In January 2026, Jacquemus introduced the founder's grandmother, Liline Jacquemus, as its first brand ambassador. This connects the visual world to family history instead of aesthetic styling alone. [06]

**MY ANALYSIS**

The competitive advantage is continuity: origin story, casting, location and product repeatedly communicate the same feeling.



Le Coup de Soleil, SS20. Image courtesy of Jacquemus.

**WHAT AN EMERGING BRAND CAN BORROW**

Define three repeatable visual codes - a location, a color family and a styling gesture - then build a six-image series around one real founder memory. Measure saves, shares, branded search and unaided creative recognition.



Grace Wales Bonner. Portrait: Liz Johnson Artur / Wales Bonner.

### CULTURAL ROUTE / DEPTH

## Wales Bonner: when research becomes luxury

A strong cultural point of view is more difficult to copy than a trend.

### THE BRAND'S DISTINCTIVE POSITION

Wales Bonner defines its work through European heritage and an Afro-Atlantic spirit, informed by sustained cultural research. [07]

### THE CULTURAL PROOF

The 2019 Serpentine exhibition A Time for New Dreams extended this world into art, ritual, sound and collaboration - evidence that the perspective exists beyond a seasonal campaign. [08]

### THE COMMERCIAL TRANSLATION

The adidas collaboration applied that perspective to familiar sportswear and sneakers, grounding the collection in Jamaican heritage and considered craft. [09]

### MY ANALYSIS

Research creates defensible differentiation when it influences product, collaborators and narrative - and when the people and histories involved are respected and credited.



adidas Originals by Wales Bonner. Image courtesy of adidas.

### WHAT AN EMERGING BRAND CAN BORROW

Document a real craft, community or place; collaborate with its originators; credit contributors; and publish the product alongside a short editorial. Measure qualified collaboration enquiries, relevant press coverage, full-price sell-through and audience sentiment.

## 05 / FROM OBSERVATION TO ACTION

# What fashion brands should do next

**01 Define the point of view.**

Describe whose story the brand tells and why it matters beyond the product.

**02 Own one recognizable code.**

Repeat one product shape, visual cue or styling signature until it becomes legible.

**03 Give the community a real role.**

Invite customers into casting, product feedback, pre-orders or local gatherings.

**04 Build meaning into the product.**

Use considered materials, credited collaborators and a documented origin story.

**05 Repeat the idea across touchpoints.**

Align campaigns, packaging, collaborations and customer experience.

**THE BUSINESS PRINCIPLE**

Cultural relevance is not created by looking expensive. It is built when a brand becomes a meaningful symbol that its audience can recognize, participate in and carry forward.

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